

Fury at City Hall for rebuild delays

Months after fire, unrealized Palisades library and rec center symbolize frustration.

By Hailey Branson-Potts

They had come to hear plans for the privately funded rebuilding of the Palisades Recreation Center that was badly damaged in the January fire that tore through Pacific Palisades. Most of the hundreds crammed into the rec center's old gym cheered about plans for new park space, pickleball courts and basketball hoops to be paid for by some of Los Angeles' wealthiest and most prominent philanthropists. But that Tuesday night — nine months to the day since the Palisades fire began — they were angry, too. With City Hall.

During public comments, Jeremy Padawer, whose home in the Palisades burned, said of the city-owned rec center: "We need this. We need churches, we need synagogues, we need grocery stores. We need hope."

But he said he didn't trust the municipal government to run the beloved rec center and reminded the crowd that the city, which is navigating the complex recovery from one of the costliest and most destructive fires in its history, is "a billion dollars in debt."

"What are they going to do with this brand-new facility when [philanthropists] turn the keys over to them?" he asked. "Do we trust them?"

"No!" the crowd shouted. He added: "Where is Mayor Bass?" The audience cheered. Someone hollered back: "Lost cause!"

Bass and other city leaders dispute they have neglected the fire-ravaged Palisades, but the scene encapsulated the anger and disappointment with City Hall that has been building in one of Los Angeles' wealthiest neighborhoods. There, scores of yard signs depict the mayor wearing clown makeup à la the Joker. On one cleared lot, an enormous sign, roughly 7 feet tall,



MYUNG J. CHUN Los Angeles Times



ALLEN J. SCHABEN Los Angeles Times

TOP: The Santa Ynez Reservoir, now back online, was empty when the Palisades fire erupted in January. Above, where a home once stood, a sign calls for the mayor's resignation. City leaders reject assertions that they've been slow to respond.

A dangerous wait for water trucks during Palisades fire

Report reveals ways crews were stymied in getting vital supplies during January blaze.

By Hannah Fry and Ian James

When fire hydrants ran dry in the first hours of the Palisades fire, firefighters faced confusion and costly delays in getting vital water trucks into the area to help fight the destructive blaze, new city documents revealed.

It took some time for officials to secure so-called tender trucks and when they finally arrived, the fire was so intense they needed escorts to get to the front lines, according to the Los Angeles Fire Department's after-action report released last week.

"Engineers were needed to shuttle water from further locations, further delaying suppression efforts," the report said.

The revelations underscore how scarce water supplies hampered the Palisades fire fight.

As the inferno consumed homes Jan. 7, some hydrants ran dry in high-elevation areas, The Times has reported. The 117-million gallon Santa Ynez Reservoir — long seen as a lifeline for the Palisades — was empty and undergoing repairs.

Rick Crawford, a former LAFD battalion chief who retired from the agency in 2024, said that if the Fire Department had spoken with the Department of Water and Power after the wind forecast came in, the agency likely would have known firefighters would face water issues in the Palisades. Then they could have prepared, he said.

"They had ample opportunity to have these discussions and implement their water tender strategy," Crawford said. "None of this was done."

The water pressure from the hydrants fell as the fire

[See Wait, A11]

'It's hard to see so many kids die'

U.S. medical workers bear witness to Gaza's humanitarian catastrophe

By Kate Linticum

When Texas neurologist Hamid Kadiwala told his parents he was heading to Gaza to volunteer at a hospital there, they begged him to reconsider.

"Why would you take that risk?" they asked. What about his Fort Worth medical practice? His wife? His four children?

But Kadiwala, 42, had been deeply shaken by images from Gaza of mass death and destruction and felt a responsibility to act. Israel's siege on the small, densely populated Gaza Strip was "a history-shaking event," Kadiwala said. "I want my kids to be able to say that their father was one of those who tried to help."

Kadiwala is one of dozens of American doctors and nurses who



ANDEE VAUGHAN

TRAUMA nurse Andee Vaughan, bottom right, worked at Al-Quds Hospital in Gaza City, where "survival mode" became the norm.

In Venezuela, a polarizing peace laureate

By Mery Mogollon, Patrick J. McDonnell, Kate Linticum and Ana Ceballos

CARACAS, Venezuela — Some viewed the news as signaling the beginning of the end of the economic, political and social calamity

that, for the last decade, has engulfed Venezuela, prompting millions to flee their South American homeland.

"When I saw the news, I cried, hugged my children and prayed," said Mari Carmen Bermúdez, 34, a supermarket cashier in Caracas. "I feel like our nightmare will

end soon."

Others said the award of the Nobel Peace Prize to María Corina Machado — a veteran antigovernment activist who lives here in hiding — was just the latest chapter in the U.S.-led plot to overthrow President Nicolás Maduro.

"In my opinion, *señora*

Machado has never called for peace in the country, only for war," said Yober David Avalos, 28, an appliance repairman and motorcycle taxi driver. "I don't think she's a persecuted politician. From her hideout she has called for an invasion of Venezuela."

[See Nobel, A4]

AIDS activist hopeful in dark times

Founder of the Black AIDS Institute reflects as decades of progress come under attack.

By Tyrone Beason

The year was 1987. Phill Wilson was 31, a recent transplant to L.A. from his hometown of Chicago. A mysterious infection that weakened its hosts' immune systems was killing people at a terrifying rate, while the Reagan administration downplayed and openly joked about the disease. Some major news outlets initially wrote off the emerging epidemic as a "gay plague," insinuating that other Americans didn't need to worry about it.

Wilson's doctor told him that he was HIV-positive, had six months to live and that he should get his affairs in order.

Instead, Wilson decided to "focus on the living."

"Let's use the time I have to do something," he recalls thinking.

"My life," Wilson says now, at age 69, "is that something."

Wilson went on to found L.A.'s Black AIDS Institute, using the nonprofit think tank to draw attention to the lack of outreach, prevention and treatment programs tailored to Black Americans — despite the disproportionate toll that AIDS had taken on them.

Wilson not only defied his doctor's orders. He also defied the odds, surviving one of the world's deadliest epidemics, along the way preaching the message of prevention and care, from demonstrations in the nation's capital to the sanctified realm of the Black church.

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It's been 40 years since

[See Wilson, A9]

Gaza residents return to ruins

As tens of thousands of Palestinians trek to shattered homes, Israelis eagerly await hostages. **WORLD, A3**

Tree removal pains Altadena

Tempers flare as chain saws take out seemingly healthy specimens in fire-ravaged area. **CALIFORNIA, B1**

Rocking on way to Hall of Fame

Pop maverick and eternal misfit Cyndi Lauper speaks out on work still to be done. **ENTERTAINMENT, E1**

Weather

Sunny.
L.A. Basin: 80/60. **B7**

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DIANE KEATON, 1946 – 2025

A cinematic legend and eclectic style icon

By Joshua Rothkopf

Diane Keaton, whose effortless naturalism made her a perfect foil to so many live-wire actors of the 1970s in movies such as "The Godfather," "The Godfather Part II" and "Annie Hall," has died. She was 79.

In an extraordinary run during the era when she was dominant, Keaton's career spanned the high points of American cinema: Francis Ford Coppola's Mafia saga



CHRIS PIZZELLO Invision / Associated Press

ELEGANCE IN ECCENTRICITY
Diane Keaton received four Oscar nominations, winning for her work in 1977's "Annie Hall."

and several of Woody Allen's urbane comedies, climaxing in an Oscar win for her culture-changing turn as the title character in 1977's "Annie Hall." Her catchphrase, "Oh well, la-di-da, la-di-da," became iconic.

Over her career, she received four Oscar nominations for lead actress, winning for "Annie Hall."

Her death was first reported by People and confirmed by the New York Times, citing a family spokesperson. No cause of death was released.

Born in Los Angeles in

[See Keaton, A14]